RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO THE MISHNAH

The Secrets Behind the Stories: Aggadah Explained

Rambam's Intro to the Mishnah, Part 6

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to the Commentary on the Mishnah (Rav Shilat's edition), on the *derashot* and aggadah of the Sages

Shiur: Part 6 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to the Mishnah, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 24 June 2025

These notes are based on a machine transcript of the recording (no Sofer transcript exists for this class).

Recap

The Oral tradition came from Moshe; each generation's Sages derived new laws (a **prophet** has no extra authority); **Rabbi Yehudah HaNasi** gathered everything into the Mishnah, whose **orders and tractates** the Rambam explained one by one. Then, about **250 years later**, **Ravina and Rav Ashi**, the last Sages, composed the **Talmud**, with **four purposes**:

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1	**Explanation**	Interpreting the Mishnah, with the disputes and each side's proofs
2	**Ruling**	In the Mishnah's disputes and over its interpretation
3	**Additions**	Laws derived from the Mishnah, and *gezerot* and *takkanot* up to the Gemara
4	**Derashot**	**Tonight**

The first three are **halachah**. The fourth is **aggadah**: the Sages **take a verse and play on it**, and sometimes the result looks **far-fetched**. Why did they do it?

An Example: Kinah, Dimonah, Adadah

A verse lists towns in Yehudah: **קינה ודימונה ועדעדה**. A Sage was asked what it means: *it's a list of cities, isn't it?* "**Really? Is that the purpose of the verse?**" (Gittin 7a):

קינה: whoever has a **grievance** (*kinah*) against his fellow

ודימונה: and keeps **silent** (*domem*)

ועדעדה: will take up his cause **He who dwells forever** (*adei ad*).

And another list: **צקלג ומדמנה וסנסנה**: whoever has cause to **cry out and argue** (*tza'ak*) and **keeps silent** (*domem*), **He who dwells in the thornbush** (*sneh*, the burning bush) will act for him.

"The Talmud is **scattered** with these. You read them and think: **what on earth are they saying?** Sometimes it seems really far-fetched, really obscure. People think: *what are these rabbis on about? It's ridiculous.*"

Don't Skip the Aggadah

"**In many yeshivot I was in**, when we reached a section of aggadah in the tractate, the rabbi would say: ***skip it, go on to the next bit.*** Maybe we were too young to appreciate it."

The Rambam: don't think it lacks value. In it are **the most beautiful and deep wonders of wisdom**, everything **the philosophers of every generation** sought to understand. Read simply, it looks ridiculous; delve into it, and **you uncover the deepest wisdom, which the Sages did not want simply to give out.**

"The deeper something is, the more it needs to be wrapped and shelled." The more precious something is, the more you cover and protect it. The Rambam was "**the first to really put this out, and everyone followed him.**"

The best place to see it: Bava Batra 73–75, "**you'll literally fall off your chair**."

Three Reasons the Sages Hid Their Wisdom

1. It invites more interpretation

The more obscure something is, the more **"fruit"** it bears: students have more room to think.

"**Halachah is halachah**: little scope to develop your own ideas. **Aggadah and derashot** are where the person who is **creative and artistic in their intellect** can bring out the beauty of the mind, with completely different interpretations. **That's the beauty of aggadah.**"

2. To keep secrets from those who can't receive them

To blind the eyes of fools, who would never grasp these truths if presented bare. That's why **it's forbidden to teach the secrets of Torah to the unprepared**: the wise always kept their secrets to themselves.

Rav Yosef and the Sages of Pumbedita (Chagigah 13a)

The Rambam doesn't name him; the Gemara does: **Rav Yosef** (end of the 3rd century).

Two great bodies of secret wisdom, as the Talmud identifies them. "Ask someone today where our secrets are, they'll say **the Zohar**. The Zohar wasn't around then."

	מעשה בראשית, the work of Creation	מעשה מרכבה, the Chariot
Text	The opening chapters of Bereishit	**Yechezkel's** vision (the Shavuot haftarah)
Content (Moreh Nevuchim)	Everything Hashem made: **the sciences**, geography, mathematics, astronomy; today, physics, chemistry	**Hashem Himself**: philosophy and theology
Rav Yosef	Weak in it	**Expert**

The deal: *you teach me Bereishit, I'll teach you Merkavah.* They taught him. **Then he refused.**

Isn't that fraud? "God forbid" that Rav Yosef, with all his wisdom, did it out of **jealousy**, a trait found **"only in fools." Learning with them, he realised they couldn't grasp Ma'aseh Merkavah**, so he couldn't teach it.

The Gemara's source: **דבש וחלב תחת לשונך** (Shir HaShirim): the sweetest things, honey and milk, must sometimes stay **under the tongue**, kept quietly.

The children's midrash book

"There are lovely books, *The Midrash Says*, *The Little Midrash Says*, with cartoons. Children read them. **Fantastic.** The danger is **adults** reading them and thinking **that's what Torah is**."

Batya and the baby Moshe: ותשלח את אמתה ותקחה. In context, **אמה** is a **maidservant**: she sent her maid. But the Midrash notices the maids were called **נערות** a moment before, and reads **אמה** as **forearm** (as in the measure, an *amah*): **her arm grew miraculously long** and reached the baby.

"Of course her arm didn't grow." The Sages' message is fairly plain to anyone who thinks: **there's nothing you can't do if you truly want to.** Normally she couldn't have reached him, but **her compassion**, the crying baby, gave her extra strength. "You've heard of **mothers who see their baby in peril** and suddenly do something extraordinary to save it." "That's a **simple** midrash; there are far deeper ones."

What we should do

- **Work hard** and sharpen the intellect, **and pray**: **גל עיני ואביטה נפלאות מתורתך** (Tehillim 119): *open my eyes, that I may see wonders from Your Torah.*
- **If you grasp some secrets, keep them to yourself**, or share them privately with someone **on your level or higher**. "Simple people won't understand, **and they'll mock you**."

Public Kabbalah classes. "Recently, in Israel, rabbis give **Kabbalah shiurim for the public**. People who never opened a Talmud come in the evening, get excited: *wow, I know the secrets of Hashem!* **This is exactly what I'm saying: don't.** Even a tiny drop, **keep it to yourself.**"

> **פרדס**: **פשט** (plain), **רמז** (hints, numerical values), **דרש** (what we're learning now), **סוד**. "It's called ***sod*** because **it's meant to stay a *sod***. We teach derashot publicly. **The secrets, never**."

3. Most people can only receive stories

Teaching **the masses**, "including women and children," the Rambam says, and the undeveloped, you can only give **stories, riddles and parables**. So the Sages spoke of deep things **בדרך רמז**, by hint: **the deep take the depth; the simple keep the simple layer.**

Blame Yourself, Not the Sages

If a rabbinic statement seems bizarre and far from logic, don't attribute the failure to the Sages' words. Attribute it to your own intellect. Intellects differ, just as temperaments do; you can't compare a fully developed intellect with one that exists only in potential.

The Rambam's parable: the size of the sun

Take a man expert in **medicine, mathematics, music and the sciences**, but **ignorant of astronomy**. Tell him **the sun is 166⅜ times the size of the earth**.

He'll say it's **ridiculous**: *how can someone on earth, unable to travel around it, barely able to look at it, calculate its size to three-eighths?* **He'd be sure.** But let him learn astronomy and read **the Almagest** ("I googled this": **Claudius Ptolemy**, 2nd-century Greek mathematician and astronomer, on the motions of the stars and planets) and **he'll be as certain of 166⅜ as that the sun exists.**

(Today's figure: the sun's diameter is about 109 times the earth's. "Close, but still.")

All the more so someone who never developed his intellect at all, whose only intellectual life went "**from his mother's understanding to his wife's**." He'd mock the Sages outright. *(The Rabbi noted the Rambam "was not the biggest fan of women"; in that culture women were unlearned.)*

So: never say *this makes no sense, it's wrong.* **Study more wisdom, more disciplines**, until you understand. The Rambam holds that **the sciences are an essential part of the wisdom of Torah**; in the Moreh he writes that a prophet must master them too.

The Sages blamed themselves

The Talmudic Sages had **developed intellects**, a **whole community** of scholars, and **rejected worldly luxury**. Yet when they couldn't understand their predecessors, they said: **לבם של ראשונים כפתחו של אולם, ושלנו כפתחו של מחט סדקית**: the hearts of earlier generations were **like the great hall's doorway; ours are like the eye of a needle.**

How much more so us. The Rambam names **four obstacles** in his own day:

1	**חולשת השכל**: the intellect has weakened
2	**חוזק התאוה**: desires are stronger
3	**Laziness** in pursuing wisdom
4	**Pursuit of the world's luxuries**

"How on earth can you say it's the Sages' fault for not explaining, and not your own?"

"Boiling excrement"

The Gemara (Gittin 57a): כל המלעיג על דברי חכמים נידון בצואה רותחת: whoever mocks the Sages' words is judged in **boiling excrement**.

The Rambam: a **metaphor**. The punishment is **eternal foolishness**. Mock the Sages instead of delving into them, and you stay **forever in that filth of ignorance**, never developing yourself.

So the Sages commanded us to study Torah by night, and by day whenever we don't need to work.

A Cliffhanger: "Only the Four Cubits of Halachah"

אין לו להקב״ה בעולמו אלא ארבע אמות של הלכה בלבד.

The Holy One has nothing in His world but the four cubits of halachah.

This seems to contradict everything the Rambam just said: the goal is the **secrets** hidden in aggadah, yet this says **God cares only about halachah**. And at face value it **can't** be true: in the days of **Shem, Ever and Avraham** there **was no fixed halachah**. Does God care nothing for all other wisdom?

"**I don't know if you've noticed what he's doing here.** He proves his point with a statement that **superficially goes against it**, then shows that **its depth means the opposite**: a living example of an aggadah whose surface meaning is wrong."

But first he must ask: **what is the purpose of humanity, and of the whole universe?**

Summary

1. The Talmud's fourth element is ***derashot*** and **aggadah**, which often look **far-fetched** (Kinah, Dimonah, Adadah).
2. **Don't skip them**, as many yeshivot do. They hold **the deepest wisdom**, wrapped up **because** it's precious.
3. **Three reasons** for the wrapping: **(1)** it invites **creative interpretation**; **(2) secrets** must be kept from those who can't receive them (**Rav Yosef** and Pumbedita; **honey and milk under the tongue**; no public Kabbalah; ***sod* stays *sod***); *(3) the masses can only receive stories: Batya's arm**.
4. **If it seems absurd, blame yourself**, as the **sun's size** seems absurd to a wise man who knows no astronomy. Study more disciplines; **pray**: **גל עיני**.
5. The Talmudic Sages said **our hearts are a needle's eye**. In the Rambam's time: weaker minds, stronger desires, laziness, luxury.
6. **Mocking the Sages** = "**boiling excrement**" = **eternal foolishness**.
7. Next: **"the four cubits of halachah"**, and the purpose of humanity.

Coming Up

Next Tuesday, back at 8–9: the purpose of the universe and of human beings, and how it unlocks **"the four cubits of halachah."** (Thursday's halachah shiur may move because of a wedding; watch the group.)

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/LbnCGFgo0LQ · More shiurim: rabbikada.com